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**Constructing A Utopian History in
Alexander Dovzhenko's *Earth* (1929) and Sergei Eisenstein's *Old and New* (1929)
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ABSTRACT

This thesis analyzes and compares two films of Soviet cinema—Alexander Dovzhenko’s *Earth* (1929) and Sergei Eisenstein’s *Old and New* (1929), in order to examine their representation of history. Both films address collectivization and were created during a transformative period in Soviet cinema when Formalist experimentation was giving way to the emerging Socialist Realism endorsed by the Bolsheviks. Using David Bordwell’s theoretical framework from *Narration in the Fiction Film* (1985), this study explores the narrative structures of these films and their portrayal of history within the historical-materialist mode. While Bordwell’s categorization offers a useful lens, this thesis argues that it often groups stylistically and regionally distinct films together, overlooking nuances such as Dovzhenko’s Ukrainian perspective, which shapes his unique representation of Soviet history.

To further analyze historical representation, Eleftheria Thanouli’s *History and Film: A Tale of Two Disciplines* (2018) is employed, applying her framework of Narrative, Argument, and Ideological Implication. Through these modes, the thesis examines the films’ syuzhet, characters, style, and editing, revealing how even seemingly unified examples of the historical-materialist mode depict the same historical event in distinct ways. Eisenstein’s *Old and New* presents collectivization as an inevitable triumph of Bolshevik ideology, employing episodic structure and blatant propaganda. Conversely, Dovzhenko’s *Earth* adopts a more restrained, poetic approach, portraying the coexistence of old and new ways of life.

Ultimately, while both films fit within Bordwell’s historical-materialist mode, their divergent approaches to narrative and style underscore the limitations of rigid categorization. By integrating Thanouli’s framework, this thesis highlights the importance of acknowledging regional, stylistic, and ideological differences in Soviet cinema, illustrating how *Old and New* and *Earth* present conflicting visions of collectivization despite their shared historical context.

Keywords: Dovzhenko, Eisenstein, Soviet films, History, Propaganda

INTRODUCTION

For us, of all forms of art, the cinema is the most important.
Lenin

After watching *Battleship Potemkin* (1925), *Strike* (1925), or *Mother* (1927), one might be tempted to categorize all 1920s Soviet films as stylistically and thematically similar. This perception is reinforced by the theoretical works of directors like Sergei Eisenstein, Lev Kuleshov, and Vsevolod Pudovkin, who helped establish the foundational style of Soviet cinema. However, Soviet films from the 1920s are far from monolithic. This thesis will analyze and compare two representative films of Soviet historical cinema—Alexander Dovzhenko's *Earth* (1929) and Sergei Eisenstein's *Old and New* (1929)—to explore how they represent history. These films were chosen not only because they both address the same historical event, collectivization, but also because they were made during the same period by two of the most prominent Soviet directors. Moreover, 1929 marked a pivotal year in Soviet cinema, as the experimental and avant-garde styles of Formalism were falling out of favor, and the new genre of Socialist Realism, endorsed by the Bolsheviks, was beginning to emerge.

Earth was the third film in Alexander Dovzhenko's Ukrainian trilogy, shot and edited between April and December 1929 in the Poltava region of Ukraine (Марьямов, 1968, p.184). While the narrative focuses on class warfare and the onset of collectivization in the village, from the very first shots, it is evident that a significant portion of the film celebrates Ukrainian peasant life and nature (Kenez, 1988, p.427). Even the film's title—*Zemlia*—translates to soil, symbolizing nature, the peasants' livelihood, and the land they were fighting for. The plot centers on three main characters—Vasyl, his father Opanas, and the kulak Choma—and their conflicting views on the future of their village. Vasyl supports the Bolsheviks' idea of collectivization, while his father prefers the traditional method of plowing the fields. Choma also favors the old way of life, as it brought prosperity to his family, which they will lose under collectivization. When Vasyl introduces a tractor to the village, the peasants begin to embrace the new agricultural methods. However, feeling threatened, Choma kills Vasyl in the night. Grieving for his son, Opanas ultimately adopts Vasyl's collectivist ideals and buries him with the support of the entire village, without a priest. The film concludes with a funeral procession and a speech by the communist leader.

The production of Sergei Eisenstein's *Old and New* followed a different timeline, with shooting beginning in 1926 and concluding in 1927. Eisenstein filmed in various locations across the southern Soviet Union, including areas near Baku, Rostov-on-Don, and the Caucasus.

The story follows Marfa, a poor peasant who lacks even a horse but decides to bring change to her village. She establishes a dairy cooperative and uses the profits to buy a bull for the community. Later, she travels to the city to request a tractor, and upon its arrival, the village transforms into a Soviet cooperative farm.

This thesis will utilize David Bordwell's theoretical work *Narration in the Fiction Film* (1985) as a framework for understanding the narrative structure of both films and how it influences their portrayal of history. In his book, Bordwell categorizes Soviet films of the 1920s as a distinct group—historical-materialist—emphasizing their unity. He even places both *Earth* and *Old and New* in the same subcategory, “production” films, as their central theme is “the countryside that must be collectivized” (Bordwell, 1985, p.247). This thesis will test Bordwell's theory against these films, arguing that while categorization is a useful tool for understanding cinema, it often requires grouping very distinct films together. Additionally, Eleftheria Thanouli's *History and Film: A Tale of Two Disciplines* (2018) will be employed to analyze historical representation in these films. In her work, Thanouli classifies fictional and non-fictional films using three distinct modes to examine how they represent history. To explore how different approaches impact historical representation, this thesis will apply Thanouli's framework, which analyzes historical films through these modes: Narrative, Argument, and Ideological Implication (Thanouli, 2018, p.176). The analysis will argue that generalizations about Soviet cinema often overlook regional and stylistic distinctions. For example, Soviet films are rarely differentiated by region, yet Dovzhenko's Ukrainian background provides a unique perspective on Soviet history that strongly shapes his work (Kenez, 1985, p.207). By examining the *syuzhet*, characters, style, and editing through Thanouli's modes, this thesis will demonstrate how even the “least disputable cases” of the historical-materialist mode can depict the same historical event in strikingly different ways (Bordwell, 1985, p.234).

HISTORY ON FILM. CONCEPTS.

History does not exist until it is created.
(Rosenstone, 1995, p.43)

Historical films are not always easy to classify and, from the beginning, they have had a complex relationship with History as a discipline. According to historians, the primary challenge with such films is determining their stance in relation to written historical accounts. The history of historical films coincides with the birth of the medium itself with films like *The Execution of Mary Stuart* (1895), *The Dreyfuss Affair* (1899), *Quo Vadis* (1913). The genre

quickly became popular in Hollywood and worldwide, however, historical films still lack a fixed role as representations of history. The concept of re-enactment is essential to the historical film, as it allows viewers to “witness again” past events, engage their “historical imagination,” and sometimes reconsider historical facts (Burgoyne, 2008, p.8). For example, Jonathan Stubbs defines historical films as movies that engage with history or establish a connection to the past (Stubbs, 2013, p.19). Some academics believe that historical films serve as mirrors reflecting the eras in which they were made, while others argue that they can oversimplify history (Hughes-Warrington, 2007, p.4). On the other hand, scholars also suggest that historical films provide an innovative way to explore historical events and serve as an important source of information for a broader audience (Hughes-Warrington, 2007, p.5).

In recent decades, publications on historical films have emerged not only from academic historians but also from film theorists, who bring new perspectives and advocate for the medium’s ability to portray the past (Thanouli, 2018, p.7). For example, films can often convey more detail in a single shot than a written description, as films inherently capture various elements within a scene, whereas historical books frequently focus on one aspect and may easily omit others (Rosenstone, 1995, p.28). Some scholars, such as documentarian and historian R. J. Raack, go even further, asserting that films are “the most appropriate medium for history,” as books are often too linear while films can “record all the past’s liveliness” (Rosenstone, 1995, p.26). However, it is essential to remember that a film’s representation is never a direct reflection of the past; it presents only fragments of reality (Thanouli, 2018, p.231). Although debates on history in film became widespread among historians and film theorists in the 1980s and 1990s, there is still no consensus on the issue. The most prominent defender of historical films, Robert Rosenstone, has written several books and articles on the topic. In one of his latest works, he states:

Stop expecting films to get the facts right, or to present several sides of an issue, or to give a fair hearing to all the evidence on a topic, or to all the characters or groups represented in a particular situation, or to provide a broad and detailed historical context for events. Stop, also, expecting them to be a mirror of a vanished reality that will show us the past as it really was. Dramatic films are not and will never be “accurate” (Rosenstone 2018, p.33).

This statement is particularly relevant to Soviet historical films of the 1920s, as they closely align with the ideological message of the Communist Party, blurring the line between historical and propaganda films. Consequently, this thesis will adopt Rosenstone’s idea of the invention, where “films are entirely an invention, a series of sequences and images of past events that are

created with actors, sets, and locations precisely in order to be captured on film” (Rosenstone 2018, p.34). The thesis will approach *Earth* and *Old and New* as works of fiction without addressing the issue of historical accuracy.

In *Narration in the Fiction Film*, Bordwell categorizes films into four modes: classical, art-cinema, parametric, and historical-materialist. While classical and art-cinema modes are the most substantial and comprehensive categories containing hundreds of films from American and European cinema, parametric narration is a narrow and rare category referring to films whose style is either equal to or dominates the syuzhet. His fourth mode is called historical-materialist and is the only one temporally and geographically “locked” (Bordwell, 1985, p.234). It merely includes twenty-two films from 1920s Soviet cinema, which Bordwell considers the “least disputable cases” of this mode (Bordwell, 1985, p.234). He also emphasizes that these films are distinct from classical and art-cinema narration, as in the Soviet Union “creators made art obedient to social command,” meaning that in discussing these films, one should never overlook that “ideological message is inseparable from the films” (Bordwell, 1985, p.235). Thus, historical-materialist narration becomes a unique mode, as it is the only one that relies so heavily on the ideology, time, and place of its’ creation.

In *History and Film*, Thanouli expands and deepens the study of historical films, addressing the complex issues inherent in the genre and employing multiple levels of analysis to understand how films portray the past. She describes the historical film as a “magnified miniature of a historical book,” highlighting two fundamental elements of its representation: its “condensed nature” and “distorting effects” (Thanouli, 2018, p.229). Her book draws on Hayden White’s theory, which argues that written history is not as objective as often believed, with historians interpreting raw data in various ways (White, 1975, p.5). White defines these interpretations as explanations by emplotment, by argument, and by ideological implication, which help historians make sense of data and draw conclusions (White, 1975, p.7). Thanouli builds on this concept by categorizing her analysis into three levels of historical explanation: by mode of narration, mode of argument, and mode of ideological implication (Thanouli, 2018, p.176).

Thanouli adopts Bordwell’s categories for her mode of narration in fictional films and expands on them by introducing two additional layers, drawing on Hayden White’s theories originally applied to written history. The second level of explanation is the mode of argument, which “concerns the ‘scientific’ aspirations of a historian’s work” (Thanouli, 2018, p.102). Thanouli explains that historical writing is not merely a collection of facts but also an attempt to explain why events occurred in a particular way. These philosophical assumptions lead to

the development of specific “world-hypotheses,” a concept borrowed from Stephen C. Pepper (Thanouli, 2018, p.102). In Pepper’s typology of worldviews, there are four types of arguments offered by historians as explanations: Formist, Organicist, Mechanistic, and Contextualist (Thanouli, 2018, p.102). The third level of explanation is the ideological implication, which draws from Karl Mannheim’s four-part division—Anarchism, Conservatism, Radicalism, and Liberalism—and White’s adaptation of it (Thanouli, 2018, p.103). White argued that these general ideological preferences include a value system that shapes how concepts such as reason, realism, science, and social change are understood (Thanouli, 2018, p.103). Moreover, when writing historical texts, historians inevitably convey an ideological perspective, which influences their stance on the events they describe and the implications that “stem from their narrative prose” (Thanouli, 2018, p.103). According to Thanouli’s theory, historical-materialist films fall under the Mechanistic argument, as Marxist ideology is mechanistic at its core, and the Radical ideological implication category, as these films assert a radical ideology as part of their narrative (Thanouli, 2018, p.115). Further details on the nature of mechanistic and radical explanations will be explored in the chapters where these modes are analyzed in greater depth.

Thanouli’s framework will thus provide a valuable tool for analyzing the films, revealing both similarities and differences in their portrayals of history. However, before applying Thanouli’s theory to *Earth* and *Old and New*, it is essential to provide an overview of 1920s Soviet cinema. Without understanding the broader context of Soviet filmmaking during this period and the political climate surrounding collectivization, it would be impossible to fully appreciate the subtle details and nuances within these films.

SOVIET CINEMA IN 1920s AND CULTURAL REVOLUTION

When people speak of Soviet cinematography, they wave a flag inscribed: *Battleship Potemkin, Mother, Zvenigora*. But do the 120 workers and peasants march under this flag?

I say with full confidence that they do not. And they never have.

We should learn from these films as we learn from the bourgeois classics.

But we cannot begin Soviet cinematography with these films.

(Petrov-Bytov, 1929, p.4)

Soviet cinema in the 1920s experienced its golden age, with extraordinarily talented directors who learned from and engaged in polemics with one another (Kenez, 1988, p.416) Lev Kuleshov, Sergei Eisenstein, Dziga Vertov, Aleksandr Dovzhenko, and Vsevolod Pudovkin contributed to the development of cinema as an art form, earning Soviet film “prestige around

the world” (Kenez, 1988, p.416) Initially, the Soviet film industry was diverse, comprising thirteen studios, several of which operated outside Russia in the National Republics, each with its own distinct style.¹ While the Bolsheviks found it challenging to extend their authority from major cities into the countryside and remote areas, cinema became a valuable tool for winning over the peasantry (Kenez, 1988, p.416). The Soviet cinema initiative brought films to the countryside with the help of mobile projectors and established cinemas in villages, especially in Ukraine, which had a relatively advanced agricultural economy and a peasantry with the disposable income necessary to sustain cinema as a business (Kepley, 1996, p.348).

The Ukrainian VUFKU (All-Ukrainian Photo Cinema Administration) was the strongest non-Russian film studio. It built and modernized studios in major cultural centers—Kiev, Odessa, and Yalta—giving Ukraine nearly 22 percent of the total Soviet market. Additionally, studio director Paul Neches hired native Ukrainians and encouraged members of the Ukrainian intelligentsia to work at VUFKU, even if they lacked experience in the film industry (Kepley, 1996, p.349). This policy enabled Ukrainian painter and caricaturist Aleksandr Dovzhenko to join the Odessa studio in 1926, and within a year, he began writing scripts and directing films. Neches also promoted the production of films emphasizing Ukrainian national heritage and literary tradition, a policy from which Dovzhenko’s trilogy benefited (Kepley, 1996, p.349).

From the start, the Bolsheviks believed in the propaganda potential of film, and due to this conviction, cinema in the Soviet Union was never free from political intervention (Miller, 2006, p.103). In the early 1920s, however, this interference did not prevent the industry from thriving. Many filmmakers were “genuinely enthusiastic about building a new society” and produced films that “successfully blended artistic innovation with an orthodox political message” (Kenez, 1988, p.417). Directors saw themselves as radicals, striving to create a revolution in cinema similar to the Bolshevik revolution in society, “advocating a decisive break with bourgeois notions of art” (Kenez, 1988, p.416). Ironically, it was this very radicalism that contributed to their downfall, as the late 1920s became a period of turmoil. The more radical and leftist an artist was, the more likely they were to suffer (Kenez, 1988, p.416).

Knowing the power of film as a political tool, the Bolsheviks demanded the impossible from Soviet directors: films had to be artistically valuable, ideologically appropriate, and politically beneficial, while also attracting large audiences and being economically viable (Youngblood, 1991, p.149). Yet it was fairly evident that broad audiences preferred easily

¹ Even in purely numerical terms the growth of the film industry was impressive. In 1927, for example, 119 films were made, 300 million movie tickets were sold, and, on the average, each film was seen by 2.5 million people in the Soviet Union (Kenez, 1988, p.415).

digestible genres like adventure, comedy, or romance. The Bolsheviks saw this trend as a failure on the part of avant-garde directors, accusing them of formalism and of “alienating simple workers and peasants” (Kenez, 1988, p.417). Consequently, in 1926, political education organizations (politprosvet) recommended limiting resources for agitational films, and by 1928, concluded that “Soviet directors must make films accessible to the millions” (Kenez, 1988, p.419). This decision not only made it harder to produce experimental films but also armed critics with the power to accuse any avant-garde film of being inaccessible to the masses, hence anti-communist, and to assert that they would “unmask any hesitation concerning Marxist ideological positions in film arts, any kind of ideological uncertainty, any kind of compromise with deviation of form” (Кино и жизнь, 1929).

In 1930 Sovkino was dissolved and a new studio with different policies and leadership, Soiuzkino, was established. The new director, Shumiatskii—who had no prior experience in the film industry—tightened censorship, requiring every project to have an approved synopsis before production could begin. Soiuzkino also centralized the industry; now, every script from a regional studio had to receive approval from Moscow (Kepley, 1996, p.353). This was the period during which both *Earth* and *Old and New* were produced. Although both directors were at the peak of their popularity, they did not escape these policy changes. *Earth* premiered in 1930 and was immediately criticized as reactionary and ideologically harmful with a style that “made it incomprehensible for worker and peasant audiences” (Kenez, 1988, 427). Consequently, the film was censored after its premiere with several scenes cut.²

The Soviet Golden Age of cinema ended in the early 1930s, due in part to the advent of sound but more significantly to the broader cultural shift initiated with Stalin’s rise to power. In 1934, the regime promoted Socialist Realism, an approach that forced directors to focus on socialist themes in a form accessible to the masses (Belodubrovskaya, 2017, p.171). This cultural revolution in cinema was part of the larger Stalinist transformation of society, and the upheaval in the film industry can only be understood in the context of the brutal collectivization and industrialization policies that forced millions to abandon their way of life.

COLLECTIVIZATION AND ITS INTERPRETATION

I was especial happy that Nikolai II wasn’t Ukrainian, in my imagination it meant, that Ukrainians were not responsible for his miserable reign. This was my nationalism.
(Dovzhenko, 1939, p.131)

² Scene with naked women for eroticism, peasants urinating into the tractor for indecency.

Lenin's New Economic Policy (N.E.P.) was introduced in 1921 as a semi-capitalist system intended to recover the economy after the chaos of the First World War and the Civil War. The N.E.P. allowed peasants to sell their grain on the open market, which especially benefited those with larger holdings—the kulaks (Kepley, Jr, 1974, p.35). Since the Bolsheviks had not yet fully enforced their rule in rural areas, the kulaks' power was particularly threatening to them. This system created a paradox: while peasants were encouraged to produce grain to meet government needs, successful farmers risked being labelled as kulaks—enemies of the state (Kenez, 1985, p.214).

In the early 1920s, nearly 97 percent of agricultural land was privately owned. However, as Stalin rose to power, he began dismantling this system, spurred on by a grain shortage in 1927. Stalin blamed the kulaks for the shortage and declared it was time to “strike hard” against them (Kepley, Jr, 1974, p.37). Two years later, he issued another menacing statement: “we must smash the kulaks, eliminate them as a class,” and he announced both the First Five-Year Plan for industrialization and the collectivization of farms (Kepley, Jr, 1974, p.37). Over the next several years, many kulaks were killed, millions of peasant households were dissolved, and their property was confiscated (Kenez, 1985, p.166). Faced with the loss of their possessions, peasants resisted by destroying their own crops and livestock and attacking Soviet officials.

The official idea behind collectivization was that individual farmers would join the ‘колхоз’ (collective farms), where resources would be shared. In practice, however, it meant that peasants became serfs once again, forced to give up their land, property, and even domestic animals, unable to own or sell their harvest (Зеленин, 2011). Moreover, in the new collective farms, harvests were sold to the state at prices set by the government itself. By 1932, forced collectivization and industrialization had abruptly ended the era of a mixed economy.

The situation in Ukraine was even more challenging. The Bolsheviks had only invaded Ukraine in 1921, and support for them there was minimal. Ukraine’s rich agricultural lands made it essential to the communist regime, yet Ukrainian peasants had long traditions of private land ownership, even during serfdom, and fiercely defended their freedoms (Зеленин, 2011). In contrast, Russian peasants had only gained their freedom in 1861 and did yet fully grasp the meaning of independence. To enforce collectivization on Ukrainian soil, the communists had to employ Red Army veterans who fought during the Civil War (Зеленин, 2011).

Both films address collectivization as the central theme, yet the directors’ approaches diverge significantly—not only due to their distinct artistic styles (which will be discussed in the next chapters) but also due to their different backgrounds. Starting with Dovzhenko, it is

important to note that he came from a peasant family. Even though his grandfather was literate, his father was not. To provide his son with an education, Dovzhenko's father sold part of his land to pay for his schooling in the city and later for teacher's college. After college, Dovzhenko taught history and geography for several years before becoming a painter-caricaturist for a newspaper in Kharkov (Марьямов, 1968, p.28). During his teaching years, he criticized the Bolsheviks' policy of russification in Ukrainian schools (Марьямов, 1968, p.22).

Two other notable aspects of Dovzhenko's early life might have influenced his views and, consequently, his filmmaking style. During the war between the communists and Ukrainian forces (1917–1923), it is highly likely that he fought for the Ukrainian National Republic under Petliura against the Bolsheviks (Фрейлих, 1991, p.258). Although Soviet biographers attempted to obscure these details by suggesting he sympathized with the communists even before joining the party, Dovzhenko himself alluded to his support for Petliura as “naïve mistakes of his youth” in his autobiography (Довженко, 1939, p.49). Furthermore, his lack of membership in the communist party in 1922 may have been the reason he was dismissed as an ambassador in Berlin (Perez, 2011, p.17). Another intriguing detail is that while Dovzhenko's rural upbringing offered him a unique perspective on collectivization, his overall background may not have aligned with the ideal Bolshevik image. While his family was portrayed as impoverished, the fact that both children attended city schools, not village schools, and later went on to college strongly suggests that the family might have been relatively wealthy.³ Additionally, at the height of the campaign against kulaks, Dovzhenko's father was expelled from a collective farm. Even though the reason remains unknown, the expulsion itself raises questions. Interestingly, the poet and communist propagandist Demian Bednyi, when critiquing *Earth*, labelled it a “kulak film” due to its lack of demonization of the kulaks (Kenez, 1988, p.427). Dovzhenko's connection to Ukraine rather than to the Soviet Union as a whole is further evidenced by the fact that he had never visited Moscow and had travelled only westward (to Berlin, Warsaw) until he was forcibly relocated to Moscow due to the authorities' concerns about his sympathies toward Ukrainian nationalism.⁴

On the other hand, Eisenstein's background could not have been further removed from peasant life or the subject of collectivization. He was born in Riga, a city more influenced by Western European culture than Russian, to a middle-class family. His father was an architect

³ Moreover, Dovzhenko's sister became a doctor and he - the teacher, rather unusual choices for a poor peasant family.

⁴ Until the end of his life he was not allowed to go back to Ukraine, he lived in Moscow under a constant surveillance of KGB. Dovzhenko even wrote to Stalin begging to let him die on his “native soil”, to no avail.

and his mother came from a merchant family (Kepley, Jr,1974, p.37). As a child, he learned French and German, and later moved with his mother to St. Petersburg, the most European city in the Russian Empire. Following in his father's footsteps, Eisenstein studied civil engineering and architecture in St. Petersburg. Despite his middle-class upbringing, he became a supporter of the revolution and enthusiastically participated in helping the Bolsheviks win the civil war—a stark contrast to Dovzhenko's childhood and early years.

Given Eisenstein's urban background, his lack of familiarity with peasant life is understandable. Nevertheless, when he was commissioned to produce a film about collectivization in 1926, he began researching the subject thoroughly. He started by reading newspapers and books on Soviet agricultural policy and even took the original title for the film—*The General Line*—from the agricultural resolution of the Fourteenth Party Congress (Kepley, Jr,1974, p.38). One of the most influential sources for him was a book of sketches depicting rural village life, which included a diary of a cooperative farm that served as a prototype for the one shown in the film. Moreover, to capture the atmosphere of village life, Eisenstein, his co-director Grigori Alexandrov, and their cameraman Eduard Tisse travelled to a village, where they lived for a month before beginning production (Kepley, Jr,1974, p.37).

When Eisenstein began working on the film in 1926, the debate over Soviet agriculture was still in its early stages, and Stalin was supporting the NEP's policy of individual farm production (Kepley, Jr,1974, p.39). Having just successfully produced *Battleship Potemkin*, Eisenstein's initial script for *The General Line* reflected some of the same inspirations. The first version proposed a more violent depiction of class struggle, similar to scenes from *Battleship Potemkin*. The film was set to begin with an immediate confrontation between the peasants and wealthy landowners, with an opening intertitle declaring: "120 million peasants and a few thousand landowners. MUCH land to the landowners. LITTLE to the peasants. Such cannot exist" (Kepley, Jr,1974, p.41). In the following scene, the conflict escalates as peasants collectively attack a landowner's estate (Kepley, Jr,1974, p.40). However, in January 1927, Sovkino interrupted Eisenstein's production, instructing him to create *October* for the tenth anniversary of the Revolution (Kepley, Jr,1974, p.38). When Eisenstein returned to *The General Line* in 1928, Stalin's stance on the peasants had shifted, with kulaks now officially labelled as the villains. This change didn't significantly impact the second version of the script; Eisenstein merely toned-down scenes of violence and placed less emphasis on destruction (Kepley, Jr,1974, p.45). The new focus was on industrialization: machines conquering the land and images of abundance in the new cooperative farms. The primary adjustment was to the title itself, as *The General Line* referenced the agricultural policy of the Fourteenth Party Congress,

which had sanctioned individual holdings rather than collectivization. With the more fitting title *Old and New*, the film was approved and premiered on October 7th in three Moscow theatres, as well as simultaneously in 52 other cities. This wide distribution underscored the film's importance for the Bolsheviks, and it was better received by authorities and critics than Dovzhenko's *Earth*.

EXPLANATION BY MODE OF NARRATION

All my pictures are my grandfather, my father and me myself.
Dovzhenko (Фрейлих, 1991, p.253)

In her theory on understanding historical films, Thanouli first examines narration, drawing on Bordwell's categories of fiction films. Thus, the thesis will begin exploring the two films by discussing how the historical-materialist mode represents the historical past. Bordwell's theory highlights that historical-materialist films accept and reiterate their fabula world: "the viewer is likely to know, or quickly guess, the underlying argument to be presented and the referential basis of the fabula world" (Bordwell, 1985, p.236). For such films that are based on "already-known stories, drawn from history, myth, and contemporary life" and have "a fairly limited range of options", the way in which director shapes the narrative becomes essential (Bordwell, 1985, p.241). If the syuzhet is predetermined in historical-materialist films, then the director's focus shifts to "the question of how history takes its course." Consequently, these films often employ unconventional editing, mise-en-scène, and character construction, establishing an alternative stylistic paradigm (Bordwell, 1985, p.236). Therefore, several aspects of the historical-materialist mode must be examined to highlight how representation diverges considerably in two films that are part of historical-materialist narration.

1. Cause-And-Effect

While the narrative pattern may be easily recognizable to viewers familiar with Soviet films, what is truly remarkable is not the predictability of the syuzhet, but rather the director's assumption that the audience already possesses this knowledge. Thus, according to Bordwell "not all of the links need to be shown" in the film, leading to a disruption in cause and effect (Bordwell, 1985, p. 241). Eisenstein's *Old and New* is a particularly strong example of this disruption: the film lacks a solid narrative, and the cause-effect chain constantly breaks. It is structured like a collection of short propaganda messages, with the first intertitle acknowledging

this division by describing it as “a film in six parts.” For the first 30 minutes, the viewer can easily follow the plot, but as the film progresses, the cause-effect relationship between scenes becomes less apparent. After a brief depiction of the village's miserable situation, the narrative focuses on the heroine, Marfa Lapkina. The viewer sees her struggle to plow her fields without a horse, leading her to ask the kulaks for one. When they refuse, she returns to the fields and tries to plow with a cow instead. Meanwhile, the director portrays her neighbors who also struggle, even preparing to plow the fields without animals (fig.1). The narrative is reinforced by straightforward intertitles such as “Didn’t give a horse!” or “No Horse,” which repeat for emphasis. The culmination occurs when Marfa declares, “We can’t live like this!” In the next scene, she is already campaigning for the formation of a cooperative farm.



Figure 1. Eisenstein. *Old and New*. Peasants in field.

Although some steps are missing, such as how Marfa arrived at the idea of a cooperative farm, the cause-effect structure remains, with each scene building on the previous one. Even a classical three-act structure can be observed—problem, struggle, solution. This initial 30-minute segment functions as a film within a film, resembling the classical mode and concluding with the formation of a dairy cooperative. Here, history is represented through “the importance of human initiative,” and “historical time is represented as a natural flow that moves smoothly,” highlighting the notion that “history progresses linearly” (Thanouli, 2018, p.140).

However, after the first part, the cause-effect structure begins to slowly deteriorate. Following a long religious procession intended to combat the drought, the scene abruptly shifts to the introduction of a cream separator to the villagers. While the two scenes are unrelated, Eisenstein, through editing, makes the transition between them less jarring. He uses several close-ups of the peasants’ faces during the religious procession and then, without an establishing shot, shifts to close-ups of the villagers at the new location with the cream separator. An intertitle then links the two scenes: the peasants question whether the religious

procession is a “Fraud?”—a word that reappears during the introduction of the cream separator, where villagers similarly doubt the new technology (figs 2,3). Thus, Eisenstein unites two completely different scenes and breaks the cause-effect chain by skillfully playing with the audience’s expectations. Moreover, the introduction of the cream separator lacks a direct “cause”. The viewer has seen the drought, the land division issues, and the inability to plow the fields, so the logical “effect” would be the introduction of a tractor. Instead, Eisenstein shifts the focus from field work to dairy production, returning to the tractor only near the end of the film.



Figure 2 Eisenstein. *Old and New*. *Fraud?*



Figure 3 Eisenstein. *Old and New*. *Peasants*

As the film progresses, it becomes increasingly episodic, with cause-and-effect connections becoming less significant. For instance, after Marfa buys a bull, the film sharply jumps to an entirely new location—the city—and introduces a new group of characters, the factory workers. This treatment of cause-and-effect renders the depiction of history chaotic and prevents the audience from fully grasping historical events, as cause-effect logic is essential for realistic representation. In this way, the episodic structure of *Old and New* firmly places it within the historical-materialist mode, presenting the syuzhet as historically less realistic. Since this mode required film form to break free from the limitations of realistic representation and prompt the viewer to actively engage with the artwork (Thanouli, 2018, p.128).

Compared to Eisenstein’s film, *Earth* seems to follow a nearly classical narrative. Throughout the film, there is a clear cause-and-effect structure, with each scene logically building on the previous one. This structure allows the viewer to understand the historical narrative clearly and to perceive a sense of realism in the events. Furthermore, as in the classical mode, there is “a struggle to solve a problem”: the problem is the old-fashioned way of farming, which the main character, Vassil, seeks to change. He has one “clear goal”: persuading the peasants, especially his father, to accept new technology—the tractor (Bordwell, 1985, p.157).

In contrast, Marfa's goal in *Old and New* is ambiguous. First, she seeks a horse, then a bull, then a tractor, and ultimately, she becomes a tractor driver—a goal that was not previously established in the film.

Additionally, *Earth* features characters “who are in conflict with each other,” with clear clashes between father and son, son and kulaks, father and priest (Bordwell, 1985, p.157). These conflicts make the historical representation more comprehensible, as history is traditionally portrayed through clashes. Interestingly, *Old and New* does not have well-established conflicts, though it does present antagonists, such as the kulaks, bureaucracy, and other peasants. The only notable clash occurs between Marfa and other peasants when deciding how to spend the money (around the 40–50-minute mark); afterward, there are no further conflicts in the film.

2. Temporal Construction

Another consequence of the break in cause-and-effect in historical-materialist narration is an unusual temporal construction that exists in both films. These temporal structures allow the audience to step outside the normal flow of history and see the broader historical picture. In *Earth*, the most vivid example of disruption in fabula time is the bread-making sequence, where parts of the scene exist only to show the viewer how the entire bread-making process transpires. The scene begins by contrasting the old and new ways of life—Vassil plows with the tractor for the first time, while his father, Opanas, still uses a scythe. To illustrate the tractor's advantages, the entire cycle from ploughing to bread-baking is depicted, as if it all occurs in a single day. Vassil continues ploughing during the bread-making stage, with other villagers and animals witnessing the whole process. Most notably, Opanas seems to gradually accept the new way of working the land. (figs 4,5) It is difficult to determine whether the sequence is meant to represent a future vision that Vassil or Opanas imagines or if the scene is purely for the audience's benefit.



Figure 4 Dovzhenko *Earth*. Bread making



Figure 5 Dovzhenko. *Earth*. Sowing the field

In *Old and New*, a similar sequence appears, though it is more evident that it represents Marfa's dream. After collecting money for a new bull, she falls asleep and dreams of how the bull will benefit the village. The viewer observes the entire process—from milk flowing into bottles to pigs being born, raised, and eventually slaughtered—which seems feasible within the framework of a dream (figs 6,7). However, this ceases to be merely Marfa's dream, as Eisenstein informs the audience through intertitles: "You think it's a dream? / No, it is not!" With this clever transition, the film simultaneously presents the future Marfa envisions for her village and the cooperative farm that already exists. Although *Old and New* and *Earth* contain moments of temporal construction, these are not central to the films, making this aspect of historical-materialist narration less evident in both works.



Figure 6 Eisenstein. *Old and New*. Pigs



Figure 7 Eisenstein. *Old and New*. Burning pigs

3. Characters

Even though there are many significant features that characterize the historical-materialist mode, the most prominent is its unique treatment of characters. Bordwell believes that the form of narration in these films changes the concept of character, transforming it into "an emblematic force within a politically defined situation" (Bordwell, 1985, p.236). Indeed, some Soviet avant-garde directors, like Eisenstein and Vertov, believed that the communicative potential of objects could be as significant as that of actors, thus diminishing the importance of character's desires and goals (Фрейлих, 1991, p.229). Bordwell states that historical-materialist films abandoned the idea of an individual hero for a "mass hero," as Soviet directors did not dwell on psychology or emphasize the role of the individual (Kenez, 1988, p.423). Curiously, Bolsheviks and Soviet film critics complained that these films failed as propaganda tools precisely because they lacked an individual hero with whom the audience could identify and who could inspire the masses

(Kenez, 1988, p.423). This is why, in the next period of Soviet cinema, the genre of Socialist Realism adopted the concept of a hero from classical narratives.

Since both films lie on the border between Formalism and Socialist Realism, their treatment of characters is less obvious than in *Strike*, for instance. In *Old and New*, characters are defined by their class, job, social actions, and political views, though it is unclear if they represent prototypes for entire classes or historical epochs (Bordwell, 1985, p.235). Carroll argues that in this film, Eisenstein departs from his earlier practice of using a mass hero and instead creates an individual hero—Marfa Lapkina (Carroll, 2003, p.312). While an intertitle suggests she represents millions of peasants, she does not entirely serve as a “prototype” of her class, as she often stands in opposition to her fellow peasants. The audience follows her journey from impoverished conditions to a new role, allowing viewers to sympathize with and understand her. From the beginning, she alone recognizes the need for change in the village, and although her fellow peasants are skeptical about the “new way,” she urges them toward cooperation for mutual benefit.

Furthermore, Marfa understands that the farm’s success requires cooperation with the city, linking agricultural production with modern industry (Carroll, 2003, p.313). Unity between village and city, agriculture and industry, is the film’s central theme, and Marfa embodies this idea. She proposes the dairy cooperative, but her neighbors resist change, dismissively calling her “Баба!” (a derogatory term for “woman”) The sharp contrast between Marfa and the other peasants is highlighted in the cream separator scene: while the latter are shown as superstitious and reactionary, praying for rain, Marfa looks to the future by introducing the new machine. Her foresight is also evident when she argues with the villagers about saving money for a bull, standing firmly against their violence and accusing them of wasting money on drink. This portrayal not only highlights her bravery but also her objective view of her fellow peasants.

Marfa drives the narrative toward a utopian future. She takes action by going to the cooperative farm to buy the bull and to the city to overcome bureaucratic obstacles and secure the tractor. Every major narrative point is moved forward by Marfa. Throughout the story, she does not deliver propaganda speeches about abstract political ideals; rather, she demonstrates a possible future through her actions and experiences. By the end, when Marfa becomes a tractor driver, she literally embodies the “new way,” completing a journey from illiterate, impoverished peasant to progressive, skilled Soviet woman—a journey the entire country is meant to emulate.

Remarkably, Carroll even compares Marfa's story to a traditional Russian fairy tale, noting that its narrative has a "conventional fairy-tale structure, in which the hero embarks repeatedly on journeys, undergoing various trials to fulfil their quest" (Carroll, 2003, p.316). He states that Marfa makes three trips, in accordance with the typical fairy-tale tripartite pattern: the first, to the kulaks' house for a horse; the second, to the farm for a bull; and the third, to the city for a tractor (Carroll, 2003, p.316). Even visually, Marfa's visits to the kulaks and the bureaucrats are indicative of a fairy tale, as everything there is unrealistically huge, while she appears tiny by comparison (fig. 8). Likewise, both the cream separator and the tractor can be called magical objects, as the latter "abundantly flows with sustenance" and the former "pulls an apparently endless chain of wagons" (Carroll, 2003, p.316).



Figure 8 Eisenstein. *Old and New*. Marfa at kulak's house

In conclusion, the main character in *Old and New* is not a mass hero but an individual peasant woman—a "little person" similar to the characters in Soviet literature during the period of cultural revolution (Carroll, 2003, p.312). Soviet writers in the late twenties portrayed the "little man" as a vital actor on the world stage, with their small actions fundamental to the overall functioning of society (Carroll, 2003, p.312). On the other hand, one could argue that while there is an individual hero, there are no supporting characters in the film; instead, there are supporting "mass heroes"—other peasants, kulaks, bureaucrats, and communist workers. The shift to a single hero allows the audience to sympathize with and understand historical events better than with a mass hero. Nonetheless, Marfa does not possess the character depth that heroes in classical or art cinema modes have, which makes her less realistic and her actions in historical events less believable. The fairy-tale element—or, in other words, the film's propaganda—serves as another factor that prevents the audience from perceiving the events as an objective historical representation.⁵

⁵ Obviously, it is impossible to know how the contemporary audience viewed the events of the film.

In *Earth*, the situation is slightly different: there are several main characters—Vasyli and his father (Opanas) and Choma, a kulak who kills Vasyli. While Eisenstein did not personalize Marfa's antagonists (they are stubborn villagers and greedy kulaks), Dovzhenko's villain is clearly identifiable. From the beginning, the audience can see that Choma stands against Vasyli; he wants to preserve his land and the old way of life, and he even temporarily succeeds when he kills Vasyli. In contrast to *Old and New*, where a bureaucrat represents an entire class, in *Earth*, each character belongs to the same class but has different views. For example, Petro, with his pagan beliefs, waits at Semen's grave for him to speak from beyond. Depicting several individual characters with a variety of traits allows the film to create a genuine historical representation of a Ukrainian village, even if it is an idealized one.

Furthermore, there is a pattern in how heroes should develop in films with historical-materialist narration. Bordwell suggests that, at the start, they are often depicted in a negative light—they may be naïve, cowardly, treacherous, or greedy (Bordwell, 1985, p.236). Through the events in the films, these characters gradually convert to “disciplined socialist activity,” and the drama grows from how this conversion takes place (Bordwell, 1985, p.236). The characters in *Old and New* do not follow this journey of conversion; Marfa is a strong supporter of the cooperative farm from the beginning, and her faith is never shaken, while the “villains” (kulaks, bureaucrats) never doubt their views or regret their decisions. Thus, history is shown from only one angle, through Marfa's eyes, without any deviations or hard choices.

The characters in *Earth* are different. While Vasyli, like Marfa, remains unchanged, Opanas is initially skeptical about collectivization and opposed to new technology. However, when his son dies, he adopts Vasyli's beliefs and buries him in Bolsheviks' way, without a priest. However, like many other elements of the film, this can be interpreted in a different light—not as Opanas's transformation, but as a desire to honor Vasyli's beliefs. Notably, during the funeral march, Opanas refrains from singing the songs of the future, which further emphasizes he does not truly believe (Perez, 1975, p.84). The main antagonist, Choma, does not fully convert and still declares at the end that he will not give up his land, but his behavior reveals feelings of guilt or perhaps even regret for killing Vasyli (fig. 9). The fact that characters are given simple arcs and have their own wants and beliefs makes the historical events personal and acknowledges the effects these changes have on individuals.



Figure 9 Dovzhenko. *Earth*. Choma at the funeral

The most significant difference in the historical representation of characters is in their visual portrayal. Eisenstein reinforces character roles through camerawork, costumes, and overall appearance (Bordwell, 1985, p.241). For instance, the antagonists in the film are unmistakable: the kulaks are overweight, emphasized by close-ups of their bodies, and the bureaucrats are dressed in lavish bourgeois costumes, smoking cigarettes with a bourgeois demeanor (figs 10,11). More curiously, Eisenstein depicts seemingly good characters in a similarly grotesque manner. In the close-ups of the peasants, they hardly resemble noble figures, with Bruegel-like faces and mean expressions (figs 12,13). One could argue that, through their “ugliness,” the director emphasizes the unsightly state of the village, suggesting that they need collectivization to become “beautiful.” This transformation is evident in Marfa, who, as in a fairy tale, becomes beautiful only at the end, when she fully transforms into a modern Soviet woman. Eisenstein even intercuts flashbacks to her earlier appearance to stress the change (figs 14,15). One can argue that although as a character she does not develop, her change still happens but only visually not emotionally.



Figure 10 Eisenstein. *Old and New*. Bourgeois



Figure 11 Eisenstein. *Old and New*. Bourgeois



Figure 12 Eisenstein. *Old and New*. Peasants



Figure 13 Eisenstein. *Old and New*. Peasants



Figure 14 Eisenstein. *Old and New*. Marfa



Figure 15 Eisenstein. *Old and New*. Marfa

Dovzhenko's treatment of characters is the complete opposite; he avoids sharp contrasts between protagonists and antagonists, so none of the antiheroes appear as caricatures. Dovzhenko's peasants lack the grotesque features (missing teeth, dirty hair, filthy clothes) that all of Eisenstein's villagers possess. The village priests are also different: in *Old and New*, the priest is lavishly dressed, surrounded by expensive relics, just as one would expect the class enemy to appear, while in *Earth*, the priest is in a simple, even poor robe with no gold and only a single cross around his neck (figs 16,17). He does not act with authority or firm belief; he appears sorrowful and confused by the changes in his village, and when Opanas tells him there is no God, he does not argue. Even his curses at the end are seen as a desperate clinging to the past.



Figure 16 Eisenstein. *Old and New*. Priest



Figure 17 Dovzhenko. *Earth*. Priest

Moreover, there is no visual difference between kulaks and poorer peasants; Choma's and Vasyli's clothes are similar, with no rich embroidery on the kulak's garments and no lavish furniture in their homes. The director does not highlight any expensive possessions, and their livestock is in the same condition as that of other villagers. The actors playing kulaks and poor peasants could easily switch roles without altering the film's impact.

While Eisenstein uses the 'typage' method, selecting actors whose appearances clearly signal to the audience the "good guys" and the "bad guys," Dovzhenko avoids such simplified characterization (Bordwell, 1985, p.250). He does not view conflicting groups as polar opposites, likely influenced by his own experiences in the early 1920s and his peasant upbringing. Having spent his childhood in the village, he understood that status and political views do not necessarily make a person good or bad. However, this was a risky perspective to bring into a propaganda film. His refusal to clearly distinguish between good and bad characters drew criticism, and Dovzhenko was accused of ignoring class struggle and failing to deliver a strong political message to the audience (Youngblood, 1991, p.211). The striking difference in the visual portrayal of characters is one of the main reasons why historical representation in *Earth* is visibly different compared to *Old and New*, though both were constrained by the propagandistic nature of the films. Historical materialism required history to be depicted in line with a specific political doctrine, making the typage method an ideal choice, as it allowed little room for interpretation. In contrast, Dovzhenko's more nuanced characters offered a less simplistic portrayal of the world.

EXPLANATION BY MODE OF ARGUMENT

Frame will never become a letter; it will always be a telling hieroglyph.

(Eisenstein, 1929, p.154)

In his analysis, Stephen Pepper identified four world-hypotheses: Formism (dispersive and integrative), Mechanism (analytical and integrative), Organicism (synthetic and integrative), and Contextualism (synthetic and dispersive) (Thanouli, 2018, p.102). Thanouli adopts Pepper's categories to differentiate four types of arguments and for the historical-materialist mode, she identifies the Mechanistic argument as the only one that aligns with the goals of this narrative approach. This argument posits that historical events follow universal rules similar to those in science, with each event understood as part of a broader historical framework (Thanouli, 2018, p.102). Furthermore, the Mechanistic mode treats individuals as "merely instruments in larger social and historical processes that function according to specific laws" (Thanouli, 2018, p.128). Finally, within the Mechanistic worldview, the future is viewed as predetermined, rejecting the notion that history could have unfolded differently (Thanouli, 2018, p.201). At first glance, *Old and New* and *Earth* both appear to portray history through a Mechanistic argument. However, this thesis will argue that *Earth* leans more toward an Organicism argument, with some Formist elements in individual scenes. The Organicism approach is similar to the Mechanistic one in that it views individual events as parts of a greater whole. However, it emphasizes synthetic processes, akin to those found in nature, and suggests that every event conceals an underlying organic process (Thanouli, 2018, p.102, 124). In contrast, the Formist mode is the opposite of both the Mechanistic and Organicism approaches. It views the objects within the historical field as unique and self-contained occurrences, rather than as components of a larger whole (Thanouli, 2018, p.102).

1.Characters and Locations

To identify the historical argument of a film, we need to look closely at the characters in the story. Thanouli explains that films in the Mechanistic mode portray the character as merely a cog in the wheel, and instead of "focusing on the individual as a unique existence, these stories choose characters as examples of collective identities" (Thanouli, 2018, p.155). Indeed, Eisenstein, true to his Proletkult background, believed that the masses, not individuals, made history, a notion perfectly aligned with the Mechanistic argument (Фрейлих, 1991, p.239). For instance, in *Potemkin*, the mutiny on the ship is not credited to any named individual with personal desires familiar to the audience; instead, the sailors act as a group enacting the "will of the revolution" (Thanouli, 2018, p.127). However, *Old and New* has a different approach to characters; most importantly, there is a main protagonist with a "unique personality" and a "distinguished role," so the "forces of history" seem to be personalized as in Formist argument, for instance (Thanouli, 2018, p.127).

On the other hand, other aspects of the film are linked to the Mechanistic argument. For example, Marfa is an instigator of the revolution only in her small village; she is not a primary agent of the broader revolutionary process. Furthermore, the Mechanistic argument that the future is predetermined and the world is governed by specific laws is supported in the film. Eisenstein depicts various locations and classes that the revolution has already transformed—the industrialized city, the utopian farm—illustrating that change is an inevitable force and no other future is possible (Thanouli, 2018, p.201). Marfa encounters no genuine obstacles on her way as if the future is inevitable. For instance, the poisoning of the bull is swiftly resolved, as are the bureaucratic problems. Another aspect of the Mechanistic mode is highlighted in Marfa’s struggle with poverty; she does not have control over her circumstances, as her situation results from the “social and historical environment acting upon her,” emphasized by intertitles that blame the Tsar’s government for the village’s current state (Thanouli, 2018, p.124). Furthermore, the audience sees the integration of the micro level into the macro level throughout the film. Eisenstein depicts scattered events in various locations and emphasizes that all are part of a larger whole, with everyone working toward the utopian future. In different scenes, viewers may notice brief glimpses of hydroelectric plants, symbols of Soviet industrialization, hinting that every event builds toward a greater goal (Thanouli, 2018, p.102).

In Dovzhenko’s film, the heroes pursue different ideals—Vasyli, similar to Marfa, stands for the communist future; his father and Petro uphold old traditions; and Choma and his family focus on preserving their property. The audience learns more about these characters than about the masses of peasants in *Old and New*, making it harder to view them as “pawns of the historical process” acting according to explicit laws (Thanouli, 2018, p.145). On the other hand, Vasyli and other communist leaders speak of the inevitability of change, and while many characters do not agree with them, Vasyli’s death unites the entire village on a single path. The murder can also be seen as an attempt by the kulaks to alter the course of history, yet it only accelerates progress, supporting the Mechanistic argument that human agents cannot defy the governing laws of the universe or alter historical principles (Thanouli, 2018, p.201). Nonetheless, the historical future does not feel as predestined as in *Old and New*, since the conflict between Vasyli, Choma, and Opanas allows for the possibility of a different outcome. The director does not present the audience with an inevitable utopian future, only a promise of one.

Furthermore, the Mechanistic approach asserts that all singular events are part of a greater whole. However, in *Earth*, there are very few references to the macro level, except for the bread-making scene. The film is set in a single village, and the only link to a larger world comes

through the intertitles of the communist activists. Interestingly, even at the end, when the Bolshevik leader claims that Vasyli's fame will spread worldwide "like our Bolshevik's airplane," the viewer does not see how his fame aids collectivization or even see the airplane. Thus, the 'big picture' remains hidden from the audience. As a result, *Earth* can be seen as supporting a Formist argument, as it tells an isolated story that begins and ends with a personal event—the death of a family member.

2. Framing of the Action

One of the most remarkable aspects of historical-materialist films is the omission of establishing shots. While in the classical mode, establishing shots serve as cues for positioning characters within space and time, Soviet directors ask the spectator to construct the overall setting themselves. Hence, the audience "must tolerate a degree of cognitive strain" and "patiently trust that the narration will eventually clarify or justify what seems unsettled" (Bordwell, 1985, p.244). Bordwell explains that Soviet directors believed the elimination of establishing shots enables the spectator to create the "entire profilmic event" from incomplete views of the location, which need not have existed in front of the camera (Bordwell, 1985, p.243). The audience deduces a unified space based on assumptions about real spaces, spatial cues like characters' eyelines, and from the types of spaces typically portrayed in films (Bordwell, 1985, p.245). However, the omission of establishing shots is not only an element of the historical-materialist mode; it also plays a role in determining the mode of Argument. As for all modes of Argument, the idea of micro and macro levels is vital, and establishing shots allow the film to portray the macro level more prominently.

The omission of establishing shots is evident from the very first sequence in *Earth*. The scene of Semen's death begins with wide shots of a wheat field, but it is clear that this is not where Semen and the peasants are located. The scene itself is built solely on close-ups of apples and medium shots of peasants (figs 18,19). Yet, from these hints, the viewer can easily understand that the scene takes place in the orchard. With the help of the characters' positions and eyelines, one can infer that the peasants stand in a semicircle around the dying Semen.



Figure 18 Dovzhenko. *Earth*. First scene.



Figure 19 Dovzhenko. *Earth*. first scene. Semen

Dovzhenko also uses the absence of establishing shots to intentionally confuse the spectator. After Semen's death and a fade-out, the viewer sees a medium shot of a crying woman, making it reasonable to assume that her lament is related to Semen's death and that the scene occurs in the same location (fig.20). However, after several medium shots of the characters, the different background inside the household becomes apparent. The audience realizes these characters are mourning the loss of their property to collectivization rather than Semen's death. Moreover, the sharp contrast in the characters' reactions allows the audience to consider that, for the peasants, the loss of property is more distressing than the death of a family member. This is because death is perceived as a fixed part of the natural cycle, while industrialization is seen as an annihilation of that cycle.



Figure 20 Dovzhenko. *Earth*. Second scene

Soviet cinema “never canonized the over-the-shoulder reverse shot”; instead, the audience often has “no clear information about characters’ distances or angles of interaction” (Bordwell, 1985, p.243). Violations of the 180-degree rule are present in *Earth*, where, in most dialogues, spectators must make their own assumptions about the characters’ positions. For instance, in the first conversation between Vasyli and Opanas, both characters turn their backs

to each other, and Dovzhenko uses only medium and close-up shots (figs 21,22). However, from the turns of their heads and eyelines, the characters' placement is clear, and even when more characters enter the house, the viewer is not disoriented and can infer the layout of the location. Throughout the film, the director rarely uses long shots, reserving them for peak moments (the arrival of the tractor, the harvest, and the funeral) to show the village's enormous population during significant events. This type of framing highlights the intimate portrayal of historical events, the importance of the micro level, and the lack of generalization typical of the Formist argument.

Eisenstein, on the other hand, uses establishing shots in nearly every scene to demonstrate the large scale of the cooperative farm or the cityscape of the utopian Soviet city (figs 23,24). Thus, the Mechanistic approach is highlighted in Eisenstein's film through the framing of action. The use of establishing shots constantly refers the viewer to the macro level and the importance of generalization in the film. On the other hand, Dovzhenko avoids wide shot and uses many close-ups, which highlights his interest in the micro level. Thus, it is possible to argue that *Earth* explains history through a Formist argument portraying single events and characters without linking them to the bigger world.



Figure 21 Dovzhenko. *Earth*. Vasyli

Figure 22 Dovzhenko. *Earth*. Opanas



Figure 23 Eisenstein. *Old and New*. Cooperative Farm

Figure 24 Eisenstein. *Old and New*. City

In conclusion, *Old and New* fits perfectly into the Mechanistic mode, while *Earth* is a more complex case. The individuality of characters makes it difficult to reduce them to mere cogs, and the lack of a broader perspective pushes the film toward the Formist mode. However, despite the limited locations and lack of a predetermined future, *Earth* still does not fully fit the Formist argument. The film begins with a death within a close family circle but ends with a funeral involving the entire village. Although it does not show the larger communist world, its micro-to-macro transition occurs within the village, expanding from family to community. Thus, it can be argued that the singularity of the people and the circumstances gradually molds into an Organicist argument. The film ends with shots of an orchard in the rain, mirroring how it began, and there is an ongoing emphasis on nature and animals, suggesting that the film is governed by the laws of nature rather than science, as the Mechanistic mode suggests (Thanouli 2018, p.128). Dovzhenko tries to show the audience that collectivization and industrialization should not be seen as alien to the village's life, but rather an extension of natural cycle. That is why Eisenstein's film ends with shots of tractors, while *Earth* ends with shots of nature, as if promising that the "new way" will bring prosperity to both nature and humanity alike. This desire to show collectivization as natural evolution underlines Organicist belief "that every actual event in the world is a more or less concealed organic process" (Thanouli 2018, p.124). Furthermore, the difference between the Mechanistic *Old and New* and the Organicist *Earth* is subtly underscored by the use of light: Eisenstein uses it to emphasize the beauty of machinery, while Dovzhenko uses it to highlight the beauty of nature (Bordwell, 1985, p.242) (figs 25, 26).

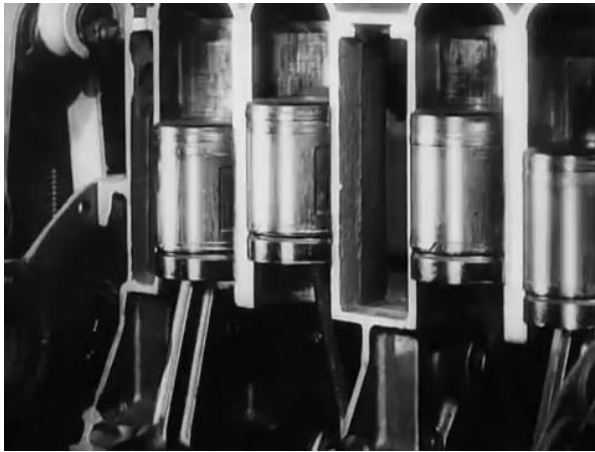


Figure 25 Eisenstein, *Old and New*



Figure 26 Dovzhenko, *Earth*

EXPLANATION BY MODE OF IDEOLOGICAL IMPLICATION

Old and New is a rather bad film, which depicts how life on a collective farm improves through the acquisition of a bull and a milk separator.

Eisenstein seems to be caricaturing his own style.

(Youngblood, 1991, p.206)

Thanouli develops her argument on explaining history by the mode of ideological implication, implementing White's theory of ideology. White defines ideology as "a set of prescriptions for taking a position in the present world of social praxis and acting upon it" (Thanouli 2018, p.103). And Ideological preferences encompass a value system that regulates the meanings of terms like reason, realism, science, and social change. Furthermore, White adopts Karl Mannheim's four-part division of ideologies—Anarchism, Conservatism, Radicalism, and Liberalism. In the Historical-Materialist mode, Thanouli argues that the Radicalism is consistently implied, with the syuzhet not being "a piece of a difficult puzzle" that needs unravelling, but instead it leaving "no room for open or multiple interpretations" (Thanouli, 2018, p.129). Bordwell also observes that Soviet films operate on the premise that the narrative should serve as an exemplary case for Marxist-Leninist doctrine, resulting in a "tendency to treat the syuzhet as both a narrative and an argument" (Bordwell, 1985, p.235). The narration aims to eliminate any ambiguity in characters' motives and the film's objectives, making "Soviet cinema explicitly provocative" (Bordwell, 1985, p.235). The thesis will interpret the films' ideological implications by focusing on Radicalism, as both films used it to explain history with a few notable differences.

1. Intertitles

We can readily infer the mode of ideological implication in Soviet films through their use of intertitles, as historical-materialist films employ “highly self-conscious narration” by making stylistic choices, especially through the use of intertitles (Bordwell, 1985, p.88). While Hollywood cinema primarily used intertitles for dialogue rather than exposition—and some European films, such as the German film *The Last Laugh* (1924), even told their stories without intertitles—Soviet cinema had a much higher proportion of expository titles, often outweighing dialogue (Bordwell, 1985, p.237). This approach differed radically because Soviet directors regarded intertitles as integral to the editing process, equal to any other shot, rather than as a supplementary element. Thus, unlike their European art cinema contemporaries, who pursued the titleless film as a goal of pure experimental cinema, Soviet filmmakers viewed intertitles as “linguistic resources for rhetorical narration” (Bordwell, 1985, p.240). Expository intertitles allowed directors to speak directly to the audience and clearly communicate the film's ideological message (Bordwell, 1985, p.240).

In *Old and New*, a strong sign of the Radical argument appears in the narrator's voice in the intertitles, which are short, direct, and speak forcefully to the viewer. These expository intertitles often resemble maxims or slogans, breaking the fourth wall to lecture the viewer. For example, the intertitles proclaim, “For cooperative work! For cooperative land! Together with industry!” or openly challenge the audience with, “Do you think it is a dream? No, it is not!” The first intertitle is a direct quote from one of Lenin's speeches, while the last references a core Marxist-Leninist doctrine: “this is how the border between the village and the city is abolished.” In *Old and New*, the syuzhet is clearly treated as an argument; according to the Marxist doctrine of Marx and Engels, the antagonism between town and country would be resolved by the advent of communism and the development of machinery, a theory that the film essentially turns into a storyboard (Carroll, 2003, p.304). Eisenstein portrays the imagined community in the cooperative farm, illustrating how the Soviet village must evolve (Carroll, 2003, p.305). He uses intertitles straightforwardly; as Bordwell notes, they are “unequivocally judgmental” (Bordwell, 1985, p.240). For instance, even before the first image appears, Eisenstein signals to the audience how they should view the peasants: as “uneducated, ignorant, archaic,” leaving no room for interpretation. Although revolution or its celebration is not the film's main theme, it still “advocates for radical political change” and presents “the utopian condition as imminent,” firmly placing it in the Radical mode (Thanouli, 2018, p.129).

However, in Dovzhenko's *Earth*, does not have expository intertitles, instead, the lines are typically brief and economical, resembling fragments of conversations or rhetorical

questions. In this regard, Dovzhenko closely resembles European directors, like Murnau, in attempting to tell the story primarily through images. A good example is a three-minute scene with a priest, containing only two intertitles with four words yet conveying a wealth of meaning.⁶ In this scene, the priest visits Opanas's house after the murder of his son to prepare him for burial, but Opanas rejects him. This moment marks Opanas's transformation, as he discards the old ways and embraces his son's communist beliefs. Through the actors' emotions, the audience perceives Opanas's grief, his anger at the god who did not save his son, and the priest's embarrassment as he realizes Opanas has lost his faith. All of this complex narrative is conveyed visually, with only two short phrases from Opanas: "God does not exist" and "You do not exist."⁷ In other scenes, Dovzhenko uses intertitles to create a specific rhythm rather than to convey information. For example, when the villagers await the arrival of a tractor, intertitles repeatedly announce "Coming!" and "Here!" These are intercut with shots of peasants and animals looking expectantly for the tractor. Here, the intertitles do not provide new information but serve as part of the visual composition, creating anticipation and building excitement by gradually increasing the scene's tempo. Thus, Radical ideology is not emphasized through the intertitles; instead, the phenomenon of unreported speech opens the film to multiple interpretations (Papazian, 2003, p.417).

During the silent era, it was common for characters' lips to move without accompanying intertitles; lip movements indicated that a character was speaking, but the specific words were deemed unimportant. In *Earth*, however, unreported speech is used differently, with dialogue titles omitted at crucial moments when a character might be expected to deliver a significant ideological message (Papazian, 2003, p.419). The first instance of unreported speech occurs in the opening scene with the death of Grandfather Semen. When Petro remarks that "for 75 years Semen ploughed the fields with oxen..." and deserves "the Soviet Labour Medal," Vassil sarcastically responds that "for oxen, Bolsheviks don't give medals." An irritated Petro then asks, "What do they give medals for?" This question remains unanswered; the dialogue continues, but no intertitle provides the audience with an answer. Even though this would be a fitting place for an ideological message, Dovzhenko chooses to leave the question open for the viewer's interpretation. The second instance of unreported speech is even more surprising: when Communist activists and Vassil lecture Opanas—likely about the Communist vision of

⁶ Four words in original Ukrainian, where the word 'нема' is translated into English as 'there is no...'. Thus, the two phrases even have a symmetrical balance – 'Бога нема' 'тебя нема'. 'God does not exist' and 'you do not exist'

⁷ Since communists didn't believe in God, for the character to say that God does not exist meant that he rejects Christianity and believes in communism.

the future or collectivization—no intertitles appear (figs 27, 28). Their passionate speech is an ideal opportunity to communicate the benefits of communist society to the audience, yet Dovzhenko disregards this ideological message. This choice allows for several interpretations: perhaps Dovzhenko aims to avoid oversimplifying Bolshevik ideology, or perhaps Opanas, being entrenched in the past, cannot grasp their rhetoric and sees the utopian future as unreachable (Papazian, 2003, p.419). Alternatively, Opanas may look away, unwilling to listen to their “new path.” Or, perhaps Dovzhenko suggests that the Communist message is unimportant, merely empty words.



Figure 27 Dovzhenko. *Earth*. Communist



Figure 28 Dovzhenko. *Earth*. Opanas

These examples challenge the explanation of history through a Radical ideology, which typically allows no room for multiple interpretations. Vance Kepley suggests that Dovzhenko occasionally avoids addressing sensitive political issues in his films (Bordwell, 1985, p.242). However, the sequences in *Earth* do not involve sensitive political issues; on the contrary, the ideological message in these scenes aligns directly with Soviet policy. It is only through the omission of intertitles that the director introduces ambiguity into the film’s ideology.

2. Editing and Style

Bordwell highlights “a narrational presence behind the framing of an event,” conveyed not only through non-linguistic elements like intertitles, but also through “the abnormally high or low horizon line, the extreme close-up that picks out a detail,” spatial distortion, and editing (Bordwell, 1985, p.237). These elements allow films to emphasize their mode of ideological implication. Bordwell notes that, for viewers, one of the most striking qualities of Soviet films is their editing speed. Every film he considers as historical-materialist features at least one passage of rapid editing, with some shots lasting as briefly as a single frame (Bordwell, 1985, p.249). He also emphasizes that such sequences typically occur during moments of intense action or emotional conflict and can create rhetorical climaxes, as fast editing itself commands

the audience's attention (Bordwell, 1985, p.249). Therefore, this editing style could be interpreted as the director's ideological message.

While Eisenstein's *Old and New* has slower editing than his previous films, sequences of rapid cutting still appear. The first occurs at the beginning, illustrating the inheritance problem in the village, where each generation must divide land into increasingly smaller pieces. Eisenstein depicts this issue with a striking image of brothers literally sawing a house in half and gives the scene a precise rhythm by alternating fast and long shots. These are grouped in threes: initially, three shots of sawing the wood last three seconds, followed by a five-second shot of Marfa watching them. In the second group, the shots are shorter, and in the third, all three sawing shots last only one second, while Marfa's face remains onscreen for three seconds. Afterwards, the sawing repeats three more times, but instead of focusing on Marfa, the shots reveal more fences dividing the land (figs 29, 30). The sequence ends with an intertitle: "land is ripped into pieces." This serves as the film's first mini-culmination, highlighting the harsh life in the village. The fast editing in the scene fiercely calls for change, thus reinforces the vision of history through Radical ideology. The scene avoids any Anarchist "nostalgia for an innocent past" or Conservative belief in the status quo.



Figure 29 Eisenstein. *Old and New*. First scene



Figure 30 Eisenstein. *Old and New*

Other rapid sequences in *Old and New* further promote the Radical mode's vision of a utopian future, particularly through the introduction of new technologies in the village, such as a cream separator. As in the sawing scene, this sequence begins slowly to convey the skeptical mood of the peasants, who doubt the separator will work. However, as the separator continues, the editing speeds up, with Eisenstein repeating close-ups of the separator and the fountain of milk, aiming to give the viewer a "total impression from repeated bursts" (figs 31,32) (Bordwell, 1985, p.249).



Figure 31 Eisenstein. *Old and New. The separator*



Figure 32 Eisenstein. *Old and New. The separator*

In contrast, Dovzhenko's *Earth* lacks rapid editing, featuring only one very brief scene—less than 20 seconds—where, during the ploughing, a peasant runs after a tractor. In this scene, the director repeatedly cuts between the same two shots, with each successive pair containing fewer frames. More prominent in Dovzhenko's film is the use of crosscutting, instead of rapid editing. *Earth* contains a remarkably impressive and advanced crosscutting sequence for its time—the funeral march (Bordwell, 1985, p.248). This nearly 15-minute scene avoids intellectual montage or rapid editing, and skillfully blending five different locations into one sequence.

Dovzhenko employs establishing shots, which are rare in this film, to show the large crowd at the march. The march is filmed with tracking shots that match the walking pace of the mourners, creating a steady rhythm for the sequence. The second location is the kulak's house, where Vasyli's murderer hears the "song of life" sung by the villagers. His anxious face is crosscut with the peaceful face of Vasyli and imposing low-angle shots of the marching villagers (figs 33,34). Unable to endure the song, Choma runs to the field, his panicked movements contrasting with the confident, dignified march of the peasants. The audience witnesses the difference between the isolated, desperate kulak and the united, graceful peasant community. Radical ideology is conveyed by juxtaposing the miserable past—the kulak, who has no future—with the communist society represented by the villagers, who move toward a utopian future.



Figure 33 Dovzhenko. *Earth*. Choma



Figure 34 Dovzhenko. *Earth*. Vasyli

The third location is the church, where the priest, bitter over his rejection, prays for God “to smite the wicked.” However, high-angle shots of the empty church make the priest appear almost comical (fig.35). The fourth and fifth locations depict contrasting reactions to Vasyli’s death—his mother gives birth, symbolizing new life, while his wife laments his death hysterically (figs 36, 37). As more locations are added, the central march remains prominent, persistently moving forward.⁸ Like the kulak, the priest represents a past left behind, while the birth signifies the beginning of a new way of life. The sequence ends with a speech about the future, while Choma confesses to the murder. But the villagers ignore him, already looking toward the future, while he, surrounded by crosses, remains trapped in the past (figs 38,39).



Figure 35 Dovzhenko. *Earth*. Priest

⁸ Interestingly, in the scene with Choma, in each shot he becomes smaller and smaller, less and less significant.



Figure 36 Dovzhenko. *Earth*. Wife



Figure 37 Dovzhenko. *Earth*. Mother



Figure 38 Dovzhenko. *Earth*. Choma



Figure 39 Dovzhenko. *Earth*. Peasants

Another element that emphasizes radical ideology in *Old and New* is the characters' direct address to the camera and frequent breaking of the fourth wall "without the slightest realistic motivation" (Bordwell, 1985, p.238, 242). At the end of the first part, an intertitle states, "Dairy cooperative - The Path of October," followed by a shot of peasants sitting and looking directly at the camera, as if posing for a photograph, clearly acknowledging the camera's presence. In the next shot, Marfa looks knowingly at the camera and begins to smile, signaling to the viewer that she has taken the first step toward the utopian future (figs 40, 41). Similarly, at the end of the film, Marfa looks at the audience, and her face is intercut with flashbacks to earlier events, as though she is telling the audience how far she has come. This flashback is not motivated by a diegetic event and exists purely for the viewer to reflect on the progress made for society's benefit (Bordwell, 1985, p.239). In *Earth*, such direct address to the audience does not occur.



Figure 40 Eisenstein. *Old and New*. Villagers

Figure 41 Eisenstein. *Old and New*. Marfa

While Bazin believed that editing transforms the profilmic event from something real into something imaginary, Soviet directors held the opposite view: without editing, an event becomes falsely descriptive (Bordwell, 1985, p.239). Eisenstein argued that long shots are insufficient to depict a real human, as film is not a painting composed of abstract forms like lines or colors; in film, a shot does not simply represent reality but creates associations (Эйзенштейн, 1929, p.116). Therefore, instead of following the narrative blindly, shots must produce an impression of the event through associative material, constructing a perception of the event (Эйзенштейн, 1929, p.116). Such intellectual montage appears in *Old and New*, though it is less prominent here than in films like *Battleship Potemkin* or *October*.⁹ For example, during the religious procession, Eisenstein intercuts shots of praying, begging peasants with images of a sheep, implying that the peasants are as mindless as sheep, following without thought (figs 42,43). He also uses close-ups as part of the intellectual montage. In the scene with the kulaks, all their characteristics are depicted through details: he shows elements of the kulak's house to highlight the status difference between them and poor peasants, and close-ups of the kulaks emphasize their gluttony and laziness. Without any intertitles, the audience perceives their 'evil' nature, their indifference to others, and the peasants' helplessness. These visual details leave no room for alternative interpretations of the characters; as with radical ideology, the audience is led to clearly distinguish between 'good' and 'bad' ones.

⁹ It is interesting that in Ukrainian and Russian "montaz" means "editing", and is understood as such in texts of the period. However, film scholarship adopted the term as a particular form of Soviet editing. Consequently, for Ukrainian or Russian reader 'Intellectual montaz' read simply as 'Intellectual editing', while in English translation it is viewed as certain type of editing.



Figure 42 Eisenstein. *Old and New. Sheep*



Figure 43 Eisenstein. *Old and New. Praying Peasants*

The most prominent example of intellectual montage appears in the final scene, expressing the Bolsheviks' utopian vision to connect the farm with the factory. Three shots of fences—representing privatization, the primary obstacle to agricultural productivity—appear. These barriers are about to be destroyed through industrialization, symbolized by the tractor (fig. 44).¹⁰ The tractor rushes toward the camera as an intertitle reads “Forward!” and then crashes through the fences, conveying the ultimate triumph of collectivization (Carroll, 2003, p.308). Furthermore, shots showing a multitude of livestock are transformed into shots of numerous tractors, signifying the transition from agricultural to industrial success. Columns of tractors and other agricultural machinery resemble a revolutionary procession, celebrating the village's industrialization (Carroll, 2003, p.309) (fig.45).



Figure 44 Eisenstein. *Old and New. Destroying fence*



Figure 45 Eisenstein. *Old and New. March of tractors*

According to Carroll, through intellectual montage, Eisenstein seeks to illustrate for the ordinary viewer the abstract social process by which simple agricultural production enables

¹⁰Interestingly, in paying a tribute to Soviet industrialization, Eisenstein left a close-up of the tractor's label, which clearly identifies - Fordson. (it was American industry that produced agricultural equipment for USSR in the 20s, the fact that authorities did not want to be widely known) “Could this be an oversight, an unconscious admission that the U.S.S.R. still was not industrialized? Or example of Eisenstein's sense of humour?” (Kepley, Jr, 1974, 45)

industrialization, which in turn further supports agriculture (Carroll, 2003, p.308). This “becomes the means for cinematic nation-building” (Carroll, 2003, p.308). It helps convey the main ideological message of the film, articulated in the final intertitle: “Here is how the borders between city and village are being erased.” Agriculture (the farm) and industrialization (the city) work as parts of a single, synchronized process.

Overall, the differences in the ideological implications of the two films could be encapsulated in the way they portray the arrival of the tractor. In *Old and New*, the tractor’s arrival serves as the film’s climax, violently destroying the borders between individual farms, multiplying into a vast swarm of tractors that plow forcefully through the fields. Eisenstein firmly establishes the foundation of a new society, leaving no room for interpretation other than that dictated by Radical ideology. Dovzhenko does not glorify the tractor in the same way. It arrives during the first half—not as the film’s climax, but rather as a turning point in the first act. While the peasants celebrate its arrival, this celebration is immediately undercut when the tractor breaks down before even reaching the village. To fix it, a man has to urinate into the coolant, highlighting the tractor’s dependence on human intervention.¹¹ The arrival is crosscut with shots of animals, who, along with the villagers, await it, thus humanizing the new machinery. Furthermore, the bulls and kulaks are filmed from low angles to emphasize their importance or their threat to the new way of life. Curiously, when the tractor is finally shown, it appears with a high horizon line, making it seem less imposing or impressive than the bulls (figs 46, 47). Through this scene, the director creates a sense of harmony and coexistence between humans, animals, and new technology, suggesting a more evolutionary rather than radical approach to progress.



Figure 46 Dovzhenko. *Earth*. Three Bulls



Figure 47 Dovzhenko. *Earth*. Tractor

¹¹ Obviously, this scene with urination was cut by the party, not only because of its ‘indecenty’, but because it was an embarrassing portrayal of the new Soviet technology. However, in the 60s the scene was edited back into the film.

One might argue that the film even incorporates elements of Anarchist ideology, although it does not explicitly portray “the nostalgia for an innocent past” as this would be impossible in a state-sponsored propaganda film. Nonetheless, the director does as much as he can to express respect for the past. In the opening scene, the peaceful, beautiful nature and the loving, caring peasants contrast sharply with the misery depicted in the opening shots of *Old and New* (Thanouli, 2018, p.125) (figs 48,49). The same admiration is extended to the animals, who are well-fed, groomed, and sometimes given human reactions—such as when a horse nods in agreement with the humans. In *Old and New*, animals are merely instruments for achieving the utopian future, as shown in the depiction of the cooperative farm, where even the brutal process of boiling pigs alive is displayed. Animals are also part of intellectual montage to underscore poverty in the village and the wealth of the kulaks (figs 50,51).



Figure 48 Dovzhenko. *Earth*. First scene



Figure 49 Eisenstein. *Old and New*. First scene



Figure 50 Dovzhenko. *Earth*. Cattle



Figure 51 Eisenstein. *Old and New*. Cattle

Still, despite its anarchist undercurrents, *Earth* largely aligns with Radical, as there is “no delay of revolutionary action to an unlimited future” (Thanouli, 2018, p.125). The film is oriented towards progress, and the establishment of a new society is presented. However, the ideological

message remains elusive, it does not directly address the audience, and there are no quotes or slogans from Marxist-Leninist ideology, as in *Old and New*. Furthermore, this ambiguity of interpretation was one of the reasons the film was criticized and even accused of being anti-communist.

CONCLUSION

If it's necessary to choose between truth and beauty, I'll choose beauty.

In it there's a larger, deeper existence than naked truth.

- Dovzhenko (1939, p.48)

When watching both films, the impressions they create could not be more different, even though they share a similar syuzhet, characters, setting, and ideology. According to the theories of both David Bordwell and Eleftheria Thanouli, these films should represent history through the historical-materialist mode. However, after analyzing various aspects of the films, it becomes evident that their approach to history is not as straightforward as in *Strike* or *Arsenal*. The central aspect of historical-materialist narration—the “mass hero”—is problematic in both films. Eisenstein abandons his “formalist commitment to the mass hero” and instead focuses the story on a single figure who symbolizes the ideal citizen of the Soviet state. Similarly, Dovzhenko also chooses to portray individual heroes—Vasyli, Opanas, and Choma. However, the heroes in both films are not as fully developed as in classical or art cinema. Moreover, Eisenstein's film lacks secondary characters, presenting instead a collective mass that represents different classes—peasants, communists, kulaks, and bureaucrats. A significant difference in the visual portrayal of characters and environments further distinguishes the historical representation in each film. Eisenstein creates a clear division between good and bad characters through their facial features, clothing, and homes. This approach prevents viewers from perceiving the characters or events as realistic, transforming the film into a kind of fairy tale. In contrast, Dovzhenko refrains from caricaturing his characters; they appear ordinary, as does the village itself. This results in a historical representation that feels closer to reality. Dovzhenko's background plays an important role here, as his childhood experience in a village likely influenced his naturalistic depiction of the Ukrainian countryside. While both films lack a mass hero, other features of historical-materialism—such as editing, syuzhet, and style—are present. Eisenstein's breaking of the cause-and-effect chain is a significant element of historical-materialist narrative and plays a key role in depicting historical events. The episodic structure of his film oversimplifies the story, failing to show how characters work to achieve

their goals, which distorts the portrayal of history. Nonetheless, even if the mode of narration can be classified as historical-materialist, it does not fully explain why the films leave such different impressions of history. To better understand this divergence, it is necessary to examine the explanation of history through the modes of argument and ideological implication.

Both films were made close to the beginning of a new movement in Soviet cinema: Socialist Realism, where the “little person” would replace the “mass hero,” and ordinary individuals, though still “small cogs in the social machine,” would have a significant impact on socialist construction (Carroll, 2003, p.312). *Old and New* easily represents historical events with Mechanistic mode, where the future is preordained and the characters’ desires and emotions are secondary. Numerous establishing shots align well with the Mechanistic argument, as they emphasize that small events in one village are part of a larger world. In *Earth*, however, thanks to the characters’ individuality, it is harder to see them merely as cogs in a machine, and the strong focus on natural laws complicates a purely Mechanistic interpretation (Papazian, 2003, p.428). The film implies a perfect circularity that reflects its narrative structure, which begins with the death of the grandfather Semen and ends with Vasyli’s funeral, where nature’s seasonal cycle merges with the human cycle of life—death and renewal (Papazian, 2003, p.427). With its focus on nature and animals, explanation of events through the Mechanistic mode feels less fitting. Similarly, the Formist argument falters when the entire village gathers together, forming a macro level. Paradoxically, for a film about the introduction of new technology, it tries to show history through the lens of the Organicist mode, since it is the only one that supports both the micro and macro levels while also aligning with a belief in natural laws.

Historical explanation through the mode of ideological implication has several aspects that are vital. The clear ideological argument in *Old and New*, articulated through intertitles, allows it to be easily categorized as viewing history through radical mode. Moreover, the ideology is reinforced through intellectual montage, stylistic choices, and editing. The film conveys an unambiguous message that communist society must be built without delay. However, the ideological message in *Earth* is vaguer, complicating its placement within the radical mode of interpretation. From contemporary critics to modern researchers, the ideology of *Earth* has consistently been questioned, and closer examination reveals why. It does not instruct the audience on the advantages of collectivization, caricature its villains, or showcase a utopian future. Dovzhenko transforms *Earth* into a “fable that transcends class warfare”; after all, Choma kills Vasil “not because he is the collective’s official, but because he was dancing” (Youngblood, 1991, p.211). Dovzhenko’s message is less direct than Eisenstein’s, who depicts

history with a radical approach from the first frame. Nevertheless, in both films, a “decisive victory and resolution” occurs in the finale. In *Old and New*, this is more explicit with the establishment of the utopian cooperative farm (Bordwell, 1985, p.157). In *Earth*, the promise of a utopian future is subtler, implied offscreen; the audience never sees the promised “communist plane” or radical change in the village itself (Papazian, 2003, p.427). Instead, the film has a circular narrative structure: it begins with vistas of the Ukrainian countryside and ends with close-ups of nature, suggesting that little may have changed in the village and that nature remains unaffected by industrialization.

In conclusion, both films fall within Bordwell’s historical-materialist mode; however, their representation of history differs significantly. This demonstrates the importance of acknowledging that categorization often overlooks the subtle nuances unique to each film. Through Thanouli’s framework, which introduces two new levels of analysis of the representation of history in film, the differences between *Old and New* and *Earth* become evident. The films’ endings provide a vivid example of how their portrayal of history diverges. Eisenstein depicts a decisive victory for Bolshevik doctrine and the inevitability of a new way of life, but this approach is less credible due to its episodic structure and overt ideological messaging. In contrast, Dovzhenko’s representation of history is more restrained, creating a sense of realism. By presenting the possibility of coexistence between old and new ways of life, *Earth* paradoxically becomes a more effective propaganda film, subtly engaging the audience with its vision of progress.

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